Employee Handbook

Contoso Ltd. | Version 3.2 | Effective January 1, 2026 | Synthetic sample document for testing

1. Introduction

This handbook describes the working arrangements, leave entitlements, and standards of conduct that apply to all full-time employees of Contoso Ltd. Part-time employees receive leave on a pro-rated basis. Questions about this handbook should be sent to the Human Resources (HR) team at hr@contoso.example.

2. Working Hours

The standard working week is 40 hours, Monday to Friday. Standard working hours are 9:00 AM to 5:30 PM, which includes an unpaid lunch break of 30 minutes. Core hours, during which employees are expected to be available for meetings, are 10:00 AM to 4:00 PM.

Contoso operates a hybrid model. Employees are expected to work from the office on Tuesday, Wednesday, and Thursday. Monday and Friday are remote working days unless the employee's manager requests otherwise. Flexible start times between 8:00 AM and 10:00 AM are allowed, provided the employee completes a full working day and is available during core hours.

Overtime must be approved in advance by the employee's line manager. Approved overtime is compensated with time off in lieu at a rate of 1 hour for each hour worked. It is not paid in cash.

3. Attendance and Punctuality

- Employees who will be late or absent must notify their line manager by 9:30 AM on the day, by phone or chat message.
- Three or more unexcused absences within a rolling 12-month period lead to a formal written warning.
- Repeated lateness (more than 5 late arrivals in a calendar month) will be discussed in a one-to-one meeting with the line manager.

4. Annual Leave

Annual leave is the paid time off that employees take for vacation and personal reasons. The yearly entitlement depends on length of service:

- **Less than 3 years:** 20 working days per year
- **3 to 5 years:** 23 working days per year
- **6 or more years:** 25 working days per year

The leave year runs from January 1 to December 31. Employees may carry over a maximum of 5 unused annual leave days into the next year. Carried-over days must be used by March 31, or they are forfeited. Unused leave is not paid out except when employment ends.

How to request annual leave

- Submit the request through the HR Portal under 'Time Off'.
- Requests for 5 or more consecutive days must be submitted at least 10 working days in advance.
- Requests for fewer than 5 days must be submitted at least 3 working days in advance.
- Annual leave is approved by the employee's line manager. Managers respond within 3 working days.

5. Sick Leave

Every full-time employee receives 10 paid sick leave days per calendar year. Sick leave days do not carry over to the following year. Employees must notify their line manager before 9:30 AM on the first day of illness.

A medical certificate from a licensed doctor is required when sick leave lasts 3 or more consecutive working days. Sick leave is separate from annual leave and cannot be deducted from the annual leave balance. If an employee exhausts the 10 paid sick days, further absence is unpaid unless HR approves an exception.

6. Other Types of Leave

- **Parental leave (primary caregiver):** 16 weeks paid. Notify HR at least 8 weeks before the expected start date
- **Parental leave (secondary caregiver):** 6 weeks paid. Must be taken within 12 months of the birth or adoption
- **Bereavement leave:** 5 days (immediate family) or 3 days (extended family). Immediate family means spouse, partner, child, parent, or sibling
- **Marriage leave:** 3 days paid. Taken once during employment
- **Volunteer day:** 1 day per year. Must be approved by the line manager

7. Public Holidays

Contoso observes 12 paid public holidays each year: New Year's Day, Martin Luther King Jr. Day, Presidents' Day, Memorial Day, Juneteenth, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving Day, the day after Thanksgiving, Christmas Eve, Christmas Day, and New Year's Eve. Public holidays are not deducted from annual leave. The company is closed on these days.

8. Code of Conduct

- Treat colleagues, customers, and partners with respect. Harassment, discrimination, and bullying are not tolerated and may lead to dismissal.
- Declare any conflict of interest to your line manager and HR in writing.
- Gifts from vendors or customers worth more than $50 must be declared to HR and may not be accepted without approval.
- Business casual dress is expected in the office; client-facing days may require business formal dress.
- Employees must not use company resources for personal commercial activity.

9. Raising Concerns

Employees who experience or witness misconduct should first speak with their line manager or HR. Concerns may also be reported anonymously through the Ethics Hotline at 1-800-555-0142. Contoso prohibits retaliation against anyone who reports a concern in good faith. HR acknowledges every formal complaint within 5 working days and aims to complete investigations within 30 days.